

The next Google

Apparently a publicly owned search engine is within reach. Who will build it you ask? The NSA will. Read on to find out how: <http://dgit.in/1b8w4tZ>

SteamOS

Valve has announced a Linux based operating system that will let users play and stream games from their Windows and Mac PC to the living room

Apps for the lazy and the busy: Order food, book a cab....

Your smartphone can do a lot more than just entertain you with Angry Birds. We tell you about some apps that can make the routine chores a tad easier

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The smartphone you paid all that money for can actually do a lot more than entertain you with Angry Birds, Facebook and Twitter. There's a smorgasbord of apps that make daily chores a tad easier. For this purpose, in this section we'll help you discover some of the best apps that you can easily download on your smartphone.

FoodPanda

Available for: iOS and Android.

Also available via web browser.

Price: Free

This is an app that makes ordering food a piece of cake (no pun intended). Be it a dinner party hosted by you or just a lazy Sunday afternoon when you don't feel like cooking food yourself, FoodPanda India offers the easy way out – order food! The service currently links up with 1300+ restaurants across various cities such as Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, Gurgaon, Hyderabad, Pune, Panchkula, Chandigarh, Mohali, Noida, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, Faridabad and Greater Noida.

From the variety of restaurants you can order from, pretty much all cuisines including Indian, Chinese and Italian, are well catered to so you can let your mood/craving decide your order. To place the order, you don't need to leave the service

– select the items you wish to eat, place the order and receive a confirmation SMS along with the estimated delivery time. The payment mode is Cash on Delivery, which we believe is the safest and the most convenient way of paying for anything that you would have ordered.

Very neat interface, but a better colour theme is something that a future update could possibly look at, because this red themed interface is way too bright. Irrespective of this, the app neatly shows the sub categories and the menus in good detail. The font style offers good readability, and for the restaurants that we checked, the prices are listed seamlessly in the menu. Special offers and schemes will show up from time to time. We were very surprised to find some “buy one pizza and



get one free” schemes on offer at certain restaurants, which aren't advertised when we walk into those joints to have a meal!

A must-download app for any foodie out there, who's too lazy to sift through dozens of menu cards!

Meru Cabs

Available for: iOS and Android

Price: Free

This is the second task that we all find quite a bit of stress in completing – booking a cab. The Meru Cabs app simplifies the task. The app, currently available for Apple and Android devices, will soon be available for the Windows Phone platform as well. Booking a cab via the app is its basic function, which is added to by real value-adds such as vehicle tracking, emergency alerts and e-bills. Meru Cabs says that bookings made via the app are activated within a minute, and the confirmation notification is immediately sent. As soon as the car and the driver are assigned, you can track the vehicle on the map through the Meru Cabs app – good way to know when the driver may be getting delayed due to an issue on the route. Once the trip has started, the tracking feature is also enabled with real-time route information on the map as well as the estimated time of arrival at the destination, depending on the speed of the vehicle. The app also offers an In Case of Emergency feature



that lets you send a distress notification to the people you've previously already registered to be notified in case of an emergency. Throughout the application, the ICE Alert access shortcut remains on the top-right of the screen, and Meru Cabs says you can use this even if you're not using the Meru service at the moment. Once sent, the emergency notification to the assigned contact will receive an SMS with the location details, and if the Meru Cabs app is installed on their phone as well, see the vehicle's location on the map.

All in all, we appreciate the safety aspect that Meru Cabs has added to the latest smartphone application, over and above all the convenience aspects. A must-download app, if you use the Meru Cabs service often. **d**